8

Léa

Now that the harvest was complete, Léa spent more time in the *chai*, helping Édouard. The most pressing problem was to find containers for the ethanol. Since Weinführer Brucker had returned only a handful of the steel gas canisters from last year, Édouard decided to fill the old oak barrels from previous vintages with fuel. But as he'd stored them outside under a tarpaulin, first, they needed to be cleaned and checked for leakage.

Léa helped him roll the barrels on their side into the *chai*.

"Can you see that?" Édouard pointed at the bung hole at the head of the barrel where lumps of white fungus grew. "We will need to brush that off and then clean it with hot water to kill the mold."

Léa brushed the barrels, then carried the hot water Virginie had boiled in a large pot from the kitchen to the *chai*. Once they were all cleaned, she rolled the barrels outside, and Édouard inspected the metal hoops. He replaced any that were warped. The final step was to fill them with warm water to kill any mold inside and check for leakage.

"Under normal circumstances, I'd dry the barrels completely before filling them." He sighed. "But there's nothing normal about this, is there?"

Léa nodded, yawning. Over the last two nights, while Rose had slept, she'd come to the *chai*, finishing labeling the demijohns, placing them in rattan baskets then stacking them in crates.

"Come on, Weinführer Brucker arrives in two days. We need to fill the steel containers and barrels with ethanol before then. I checked the vats this morning; the fuel is ready."

They had filled half the barrels when the sound of a diesel engine made them stop and look up.